



FOOT SOLDIERS The Toofan Sena, which was led by Captain Bhau, photographed in 1943; (below) a file photo of Baji Mohammad who died in 2019

Journalist P. Sainath's latest book is titled *The Last Heroes*. It's a phrase that applies to the book's author alongside the freedom fighters he profiles.

Because in a fraught and divided media landscape, Sainath is among the very last of India's journalistic heroes. Certainly, he is the only well-known journalist left in India who makes it his business to focus on the travails of the rural poor, who still make up the vast majority of the country and who remain underserved by the government and media alike.

In keeping with his lifelong endeavour, Sainath tells the stories in *The Last Heroes* of ordinary people, of "farmers, landless labourers, workers, couriers, forest produce gatherers, homemakers, domestic help... even a couple of rebel members from families of landed gentry". He tells the stories of those who have never been recognised or feted for their valour. Take Baji Mohammad from Odisha, who died in 2019 at the age of 103. He had met Gandhi and was firmly instructed to go back to Odisha: "*Jail jao, lathi khao*," Gandhi told Mohammad. "Sacrifice for the nation."

These instructions and the spirit of satyagraha stayed with Mohammad throughout his life. Sainath begins the chapter by describing Mohammad sitting under a *shamiana*. "They tore it down," Mohammad says. "We kept sitting. They threw water at us... They tried making the soil wet and difficult to sit on. We remained seated in silence. Then when I went to drink some water and bent down near the tap, they smashed my head, fracturing my skull." Mohammad is not recalling a scene of British barbarity from 1942, Sainath points out. "He's describing, softly and without bitterness or anger, the vicious attack on him in Ayodhya during the demolition of the Babri Masjid in 1992." Mohammad was in his 70s.

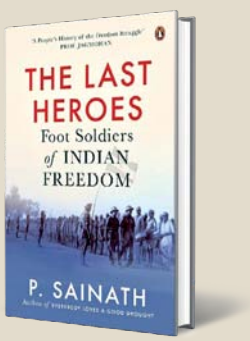
Sainath calls these men and women of the freedom struggle, the men and women who imbibed the values of non-violence and revolution, the "golden generation". In five or six years, he says, there will no longer be any representatives of this generation left alive. "I think it's heartbreaking," Sainath adds, "that the current generation and generations to come will never sit with, listen to, engage with, or speak to a bona fide fighter for their country's independence."

This book, then, is intended both as tribute and education. It is written with young people in mind. There are QR codes at the end of each of the 16 chapters, so that they can follow the stories further online, so they can see pictures and videos to accompany the text they have just read. It is an attempt, Sainath says, to show young people that there are alternatives to dry-as-dust official history, to the 'great man' approach that still characterises the way history is taught.

Even now, he points out, if one were to visit the homepage of the Government of India's 'Azadi ka Amrit Mahotsav' website, "there is not a single photograph, not a single video, not a single story, not a single statement or quote, not one illustration of a living freedom fighter." For all of Sainath's criticisms of the present dispensation, his book has been decades in the making. The urgency of his task, he says, was to record these stories while the subjects were still able to speak to him at length and with clarity.

Many of these chapters are reworkings of articles Sainath wrote for newspapers during his fabled career, extensions of his attempt to bring the forgotten heroes of the Independence struggle to mainstream attention. He traces this neglect of the ordinary In-

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